

# Dead Signal

## Art Bible

Jharek

Version 1.2 · 2026-07-06

### Table of Contents

|                       |                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Version</b>        | 1.2                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Status</b>         | Living — reflects the shipped UI in src/DeadSignal.jsx + index.html<br>(Expansion v2 additions flagged <b>build: PLANNED</b> ) |
| <b>Last updated</b>   | 2026-07-06                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Owner</b>          | Jharek (art/design/dev)                                                                                                        |
| <b>Canon source</b>   | STORY.md — tone rules (restraint, no staged bodies, the Signal)                                                                |
| <b>Companion docs</b> | <a href="#">GDD</a> · <a href="#">Audio Bible</a> · <a href="#">Technical Design</a>                                           |
| <b>Wireframes</b>     | wireframes/Dead-Signal-Wireframes.html — a single self-contained HTML wireframe, screens 01–07 (\$12)                          |

**Purpose.** The visual direction for *Dead Signal*: the look, the color and type systems, the Signal as a visual motif, component treatments, the ending screens, and the wireframe set. The game has **no illustrated art** — the aesthetic is entirely typography, color, layout, and glow on a near-black screen. This document *is* the visual identity.

**Ground truth.** Every hex value here is taken from the shipped UI. When this doc and the code disagree, the code wins and this doc is stale.

---

### Table of contents

1. [Visual pillars](#)
2. [The look in one paragraph](#)
3. [Color system](#)
4. [Typography](#)
5. [The Signal as a visual motif](#)

6. [Layout & framing](#)
  7. [Iconography & HUD](#)
  8. [Component treatments](#)
  9. [Ending screens](#)
  10. [Motion](#)
  11. [Marketing & key art](#)
  12. [The wireframe set](#)
  13. [Appendix](#)
- 

## 1. Visual pillars

### Pillar 1 — Phone-native, always

The frame is a phone. Everything is a message, a HUD readout, a contact header, or a case file. We never render a camera view, an avatar, or illustrated scenery. This is the cheapest *and* the most immersive choice — the medium is the fiction (GDD Pillar 2).

### Pillar 2 — Terminal-noir

Monospace type, uppercase labels, wide letter-spacing, a near-black screen, thin green rules. The game looks like a **dying handset running a terminal** — cold, technical, and a little wrong. Beauty comes from restraint and glow, not detail.

### Pillar 3 — The green means the Signal

One accent color — a sickly, glowing **signal-green** — carries all the meaning. It is the live element on a dead screen. Because nothing else competes for attention, the green is the Signal, and its glow/flicker is the game's one supernatural tell (\$5).

### Pillar 4 — Absence over spectacle

No staged bodies, no gore, no jump-scare imagery (STORY.md \$4). Empty Haven is lights-on and people-gone. The horror is what *isn't* drawn. Whitespace (blackspace) is a tool.

---

## 2. The look in one paragraph

A #070707 black screen. A single word logo — **DEAD** in dead grey, **SIGNAL** in glowing green that softly pulses. Everything is **IBM Plex Mono**. Text arrives as messages: the guide's in lowercase, the world's in centered italic. A thin HUD sits in the corners — battery, signal — with uppercase vitals below. Choices are bordered buttons in dim green that light up on hover. When the Signal touches the story, the screen flickers and a green glow swells. That's the whole visual language: black, mono, and one green that means something.

---

### 3. Color system

The palette is deliberately tiny. **Canvas + one accent + a semantic set + neutral grays + a warm Case File tone.** All values are the shipped hexes.

#### 3.1 Core

| Role                  | Hex                             | Notes                                                                              |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Canvas                | #070707                         | The near-black background everywhere (also <a href="#">index.html</a> theme-color) |
| Signal green (accent) | #4a9e6b                         | THE color — text, borders, gains, the live logo, hover                             |
| Signal glow           | rgba(74,158,107,0.6) / ... 0.25 | Text-shadow bloom on the live green                                                |
| Bright green flash    | #7ffa0                          | Peak of a Signal event / brightest glow                                            |
| Dim green (borders)   | #1d3a22 · #3a5a44               | Resting button borders, quiet rules                                                |

#### 3.2 Semantic — risk & resources

Meaning

Low risk

Medium risk / caution

High risk

Risk-choice frame

Gain / –noise (good)

Danger / damage / loss

#### 3.3 Case File — the warm exception

The investigation board is the one place that warms up — a **manila/parchment** family against the black, so evidence *feels* physical (paper on a dark desk):

Role

Parchment / evidence text

Aged / secondary paper

**Expansion v2 · build: PLANNED — ECHOES don’t warm up.** The ECHOES category (a recovered mind, STORY.md §3/§6) is **not** paper — it’s a mind the Signal is still replaying, so it reads on the *screen-native* axis, not the manila one. Pull it off the parchment family toward the cold-cyan “wrong frequency” tones (§3.4, #4ab5c8 · #7accd4) sitting on the raw #070707 canvas, so an Echo is visibly *transmission* where a MEMORY/CLUE is *paper*. Keep it dim; no new hue

(§3 rule). A faint signal-glow may edge an Echo when its node is powered, but the fragment stays underpowered and half- there — never a bright, whole readout.

### 3.4 Cold cyan — the wrong frequency

A cold **cyan** (#4ab5c8 · #7accd4) appears sparingly for Signal/broadcast/comms contexts — the “wrong frequency” counterpoint to the warmer green. Use it only where the fiction is about the transmission itself.

### 3.5 Neutrals

#4a4a4a (dead logo / disabled) · #6a6a6a·#7a7a7a (muted text) · #1c1c1c·#2a2a2a·#3a3a3a (panels, bubbles, rules). Keep neutral text **dim** — the screen should feel underpowered.

**Rule:** never introduce a new hue. New states reuse this set. The whole point is that green is the only color the eye chases.

---

## 4. Typography

- **One typeface:** 'IBM Plex Mono', 'Courier New', **monospace**. The entire UI is monospaced. This is the terminal-noir backbone — do not mix in a proportional font.
  - **Case:** UI chrome and HUD labels are **UPPERCASE** with wide tracking (letter-spacing ~0.12–0.18em). Story text is natural case (the guide is lowercase by voice; §8).
  - **Weight:** mostly regular; the logo and a few emphases go bold (700).
  - **Scale (relative):** logo ~2.4rem; body/message ~0.8–0.95rem; HUD labels ~0.66–0.72rem. Small, dense, phone-sized.
  - **The logo:** one word, two treatments — DEAD in dead grey #4a4a4a, SIGNAL in live green #4a9e6b with the glow and a slow sigpulse. It encodes the whole premise in the wordmark: the dead thing and the living signal, fused.
- 

## 5. The Signal as a visual motif

The green is not just an accent — it is the game’s supernatural presence, and it behaves.

- **Glow.** Live green elements carry a text-shadow bloom (rgba(74,158,107,0.6) + a wider 0.25 halo). Glow = alive/Signal; flat = inert.
- **sigpulse.** A slow 3s opacity breathe (0.78 → 1.0) on the live logo — the Signal is *idling*, always faintly on.
- **sigFlicker (the distortion).** On story-gated Signal beats the screen flickers — the visual half of the audio signal() cue (see [Audio Bible §5.2](#)). Audio and visual fire together; **where the screen flickers, the crackle plays**. This coupling is the game’s signature moment and the backbone of its audio-accessibility (a deaf player still sees the Signal act).
- **Escalation.** Toward peaks, green pushes to the bright #7fffa0 flash. Reserve it — like the audio cue, overuse kills the meaning (STORY.md §4: reveal less, imply more).

- **Photosensitivity watch.** The flicker/flash is a screen-state change tied to the green identity — it **must** pass a flash-rate audit and get a “reduce flashing” toggle (Accessibility Plan).
- 

## 6. Layout & framing

**Portrait, phone-first.** The document is locked (index.html fixes html,body,#root, position:fixed body) to kill iOS rubber-banding; the app scrolls its own panes.

Vertical stack, top to bottom:

1. **HUD corners** — signal (top-left region) and battery (top-right region), corner-anchored so they never fight the conversation.
2. **Contact header** — the current contact/location label (e.g. KIM → ELLIE).
3. **Chat pane** (.ds-chat, scrolls) — message bubbles + centered italic narration.
4. **Vitals bar** (.ds-vitals) — the survival readouts.
5. **Choices pane** (.ds-choices-pane) — the intent-coded choice buttons + the FILE button.

Message alignment: **guide/Ellie left, player choices as buttons below; narration centered** and italic so the world’s voice is visibly not the phone’s UI (protects the frame, GDD Pillar 2).

---

## 7. Iconography & HUD

Text-first, mono glyphs — no illustrated icons. The HUD speaks in **registers**:

- **Vitals:** BATTERY %, CHARGER %/empty, FOOD, WATER, HP, NOISE, SIGNAL. Uppercase, spaced, dim until they matter; battery pulses (pulseBattery) on change.
- **Risk tags:** [RISK] colored by tier — green #4a9e6b (low) / amber #c8a020 (med) / red #8b4a4a (high) — plus [COSTLY] for the no-roll FORCE. HUD register only; the guide never speaks them (GDD §7.3).
- **Resource deltas:** [+N Food] / [−1 Battery] / [−Noise] inline, green for good, red for bad.
- **Advance affordance:** a ► marker leads menu/continue buttons (► START, ► CONTINUE).

The HUD’s job is to be legible at a glance and to *recede* — the conversation is the star.

---

## 8. Component treatments

- **Message bubble (guide/Ellie).** Left-aligned, lowercase, dim panel (#1c1c1c–#2a2a2a), soft edges; text near-white but not bright. Human-paced reveal (Audio blip on arrival).

- **Narration.** Centered, *italic*, no bubble — the world speaking through the device.
- **Choice button (default).** Transparent fill, 1px dim-green border (#1d3a22), green text (#4a9e6b), uppercase, tracked; **hover lights the border + text to full #4a9e6b.** Intent-coded variants recolor per action type.
- **Risk choice.** Amber frame (border #4a351b, text #c89a58, faint amber glow) — a gamble reads warm/dangerous before it's tapped.
- **Case File — board.** Parchment tones on black; categories MEMORIES / CLUES / PEOPLE / LOCATIONS; locked entries render as ??? and warm into legibility as they unlock.
- **Case File — journal.** KNOWN FACTS vs OPEN QUESTIONS; a **contradiction** pairs two facts into the question they force. NEW QUESTION / QUESTION UPDATED cards surface in chat.
- **Region node (Phase 3).** A hub-and-spoke map: Haven center; spokes (Mercy / Comms / City Hall / Annex) shown **locked** (dim/grey), **available** (green border), or **truth-uncovered** (filled green + a TRUTH mark).

#### Expansion v2 • build: **PLANNED** — the board becomes an investigation

These treatments are **planned, not shipped**. They layer onto the existing Case File and Phase 3 screens without touching the palette rule (§3) or the restraint pillar (§1.4). STORY.md §3/§6 win any conflict.

- **Case File — the ECHOES category (a recovered mind).** A fifth board lane beside MEMORIES / CLUES / PEOPLE / LOCATIONS (§8 board bullet). An Echo is a *fragment the Signal keeps replaying* — a frozen text thread, a looped voice note, a diary still writing — so it must read **unlike an evidence card**. Direction:
  - **Transmission, not paper.** Style it on the cold-cyan / signal axis on raw #070707 (§3.3 note), *not* the manila parchment. A MEMORY is a document you found; an Echo is a mind still running.
  - **Degraded & fragmentary.** The text is mid-thought and incomplete — 2–4 lines, terse, lowercase, with the edges eaten: dropped characters, a trailing cursor that never finishes, a looped line that repeats, dimmed/… gaps where the fragment corrupts. It should feel *half-there*, never a clean block. Locked entries still render ??? and resolve into the fragment as recovered — but the resolved state stays degraded; it never fully “prints.”
  - **RESTRAINT is the ceiling — text-forward, no imagery, ever.** No illustration, no portrait, no staged scene for **any** Echo, and this is absolute for **Theo (the child)** and **Priya (the regretter)**: their fragments are the shortest, hardest lines in the game (STORY.md §4) and land *because* they are bare text on black. Never dress them for shock — no photo of a child, no visual of the moment of regret. Absence over spectacle (§1.4) holds hardest here.
  - **Kim's absence (E3) is a non-card.** At the Signal Core the player looks for Kim among the running minds and she isn't there (STORY.md §3). Do not build an Echo card for her; if anything renders, it is an *empty slot* / the search returning nothing — the one lane the Signal can't fill. Pure negative space; nothing to draw.

- **Case File — truth-by-assembly (S1).** A region's truth now *resolves* on the board once its 2–3 supporting pieces are collected (STORY.md §6), so the visual is a **deduction assembling**, not a single truth-room dump. Direction: the supporting evidence cards (parchment) sit collected; a thin green rule *draws the link* between them (evidence → the contradiction they force → the resolved **TRUTH**), reusing the journal's existing contradiction pairing (§8 journal bullet) rather than a new motif. The TRUTH is the one warm→green moment: the deduction lands in signal-green (the same TRUTH mark used on region nodes). Before assembly, the slot reads ???/incomplete — the player *sees* the case being built, evidence by evidence.

#### Expansion v2 • build: PLANNED — new Phase 3 environments

The Phase 3 deepening (~2× nodes, STORY.md §5) adds intimate sub-story nodes. The game has **no illustrated scenery** (§1.1) — these are rendered as location labels, found text, and message/HUD chrome like every other node. What follows is *art-direction restraint*, not a request for imagery. No bodies are ever staged; **absence is the clue** (§1.4, STORY.md §4).

- **The children's room (Haven).** Quiet, **not maudlin**. No staged child, no shoe placed for a gut- punch, no sentiment